



For Parents, Carers and Guardians

Controlling Relationships: A Guide for Parents

Recognising controlling friendships and relationships, talking with your child, and working with the school.

Before You Read This guide covers controlling relationships, threats and abuse.

This guide is about controlling and coercive behaviour between young people, in friendships and relationships. Some of it may be difficult to read, especially if it connects with your own experience.

- If you are worried about your child now, contact the school's safeguarding team. If a child is in immediate danger, call 999.
- **National Domestic Abuse Helpline:** 0808 2000 247, free, 24 hours, including for anyone worried about someone else.
- **NSPCC Helpline:** 0808 800 5000, for anyone worried about a child.

About This Guide

Friendships and first relationships matter a great deal to children and teenagers. This guide helps you recognise when one has become **controlling**, talk with your child about it, and work with the school.

- It can happen in **friendships**, **friendship groups** and **relationships**, in person and online.
- Any child can be controlled, and any child can behave in a controlling way. Both need help.
- It is abuse even without violence, and it is not "just drama".

Key Words

Controlling behaviour

Making someone dependent or isolated: deciding who they see, what they wear, where they go, or checking their phone.

Coercive behaviour

Threats, humiliation, intimidation or guilt used to make someone comply or to frighten them.

Coercive control

A pattern of controlling and coercive behaviour over time.

Teenage relationship abuse

Abuse in a relationship between young people. National guidance treats it as child-on-child abuse.

What the Evidence Shows

28%

of 13 to 17 year olds had been in a relationship in the past year

Youth Endowment Fund, 2025

36%

of those in a relationship had experienced emotionally abusive or controlling behaviour

Youth Endowment Fund, 2025

19%

had a partner check their phone or social media to see who they had been talking to

YEF, 2025

14%

had their location monitored by a partner

YEF, 2025

Survey of 10,835 13 to 17 year olds in England and Wales, May to July 2025. Girls (41%) and boys (37%) who had been in a relationship both reported emotional or physical abuse. Checked September 2026.

What It Can Look Like at Different Ages

Age	What you might see
8 to 11	A "best friend" who decides who your child can play or sit with, warns others off, or punishes them for having other friends. Some possessiveness is part of growing up; a pattern of fear and isolation is not.
11 to 14	Friendship groups with "rules", constant messaging, demands to see messages, and rumours spread about anyone who breaks ranks. First relationships where jealousy is seen as romantic.
14 to 18	Partners who check phones, track location, decide what your child wears or who they see, or threaten to leave, self-harm or share images if they don't comply.

Signs to Look For

Your Child May Be Controlled If They

- Drop friends, family time or activities they used to enjoy
- Seem anxious about their phone, or must reply instantly
- Change how they dress, or ask permission for ordinary plans
- Seem afraid of upsetting a particular friend or partner
- Make excuses for that person's behaviour

Your Child May Be Controlling Someone If They

- Need to know where a friend or partner is at all times
- Get very angry or distressed when that person sees others
- Check someone else's phone or ask for their passwords
- Talk about "rules" for a friend or partner

A pattern can help explain what is happening, but you don't need to wait for it to happen again before contacting the school. A single threat, or pressure involving images, needs action straight away.

Talking with Your Child

- **Stay curious, not critical.** "How are things with [name]? What do you like about them?" Criticising the other person can make your child defend them.
- **Talk about what healthy looks like:** trust, time with other friends, privacy, being able to say no.
- **Use everyday moments:** a TV storyline, a song, a friend's situation.
- **Avoid ultimatums** such as "end it or else". They can push your child closer to the person and further from you.
- **Keep the door open.** "Whatever happens, you can always tell me. I won't be angry with you."

Phones and Technology

- Help your child understand that **their phone, passwords and location are theirs**, and that real care doesn't need constant checking.
- Check location-sharing settings together, and talk about who can see them.
- If someone threatens to share an image of your child: **don't view, save, forward or delete it**; contact the school, and the police if there is a threat or blackmail. **Report Remove** (Childline and the Internet Watch Foundation) helps under-18s get nude images removed.
- Don't take your child's phone away as a punishment for telling you. It can stop them telling you next time.
- If your child is being controlled, sudden changes (blocking, deleting accounts) can make the other person angrier. Plan them with the school.

If Your Child Tells You Something

What to Do

- **Stay calm and listen.** Say: "I believe you, and I'm taking what you've told me seriously. This is not your fault."
- Ask gentle open questions ("Tell me what's been happening"); avoid "why" questions, which can sound like blame.
- **Don't confront the other child or their family, or post about it online.** It can increase the risk to your child.
- Don't insist they end the relationship or friendship straight away. Ending it may need a plan.

- Write down what your child said, in their words, and when, as soon as is practicably possible.
- Contact the school's safeguarding team. If your child is in immediate danger, call 999.

Culture, Faith and Honour

No child should be controlled through "rules" about culture, faith or family honour. If you are worried about honour-based abuse or forced marriage, contact the school's safeguarding team or Karma Nirvana (honour-based abuse and forced marriage): 0800 5999 247 (Monday to Friday 9am to 5pm). Forced Marriage Unit: 020 7008 0151, fm@fcdo.gov.uk.

If You're Worried About Your Child's Behaviour

Discovering that your child has been controlling someone is hard. It doesn't mean they are a bad person, and they can learn different ways of handling jealousy, worry or anger. They still need to take responsibility.

First, Check With the School

If another young person's safety may be affected, **contact the school's safeguarding team before raising the concern with your child**. Agree how and when to have the conversation so that it does not increase the risk to anyone involved, for example by revealing that the other young person has asked for help.

- Then talk calmly about what happened and how the other young person may feel.
- Work with the school on consequences and support.
- **Respect Phoneline:** 0808 802 4040 (Monday to Friday 10am to 5pm), for anyone worried about their own behaviour in a relationship

How the School Responds

Schools using **RESPOND** follow a seven-step approach that helps staff respond consistently when they notice or are told about harm.

For children, safeguarding is **relational**: they tell people they trust. For the adults around them, it is also **systemic**: behind every trusted adult is a safeguarding team, with records and procedures that make sure what a child tells one person reaches the people who can help. That is why staff can't promise to keep something just between them and your child.

Step	What staff do
● Recognise	Notice the pattern: isolation, monitoring, fear
● Engage	Listen calmly, and step in if they see control happening, if it is safe to do so
● Support	Make sure the child is safe, including online
● Pause	Think before acting; never confront the other child without a plan, and never use mediation
● Offer	Model alternatives and explain what happens next
● Notify	Tell the safeguarding team as soon as is practicably possible
● Document	Record what happened, factually

Working with You

- **Parents and carers are partners in keeping children safe.** You know your child best.
- The school will usually involve you, whether your child is being controlled or has been controlling someone. Both children get a safeguarding response.
- Schools can share safeguarding information without asking for consent where it is needed to keep a child safe; data protection law allows this. From 30 September 2026, a new Information Sharing Duty also requires many safeguarding organisations to share relevant information. What is shared must be relevant, necessary and proportionate, go only to those who need it, and be handled in line with data protection law. Schools should tell you what they are sharing and why, unless that would put a child at greater risk, and listen to your views and your child's.
- Sometimes the school must speak to other agencies before telling parents, where telling parents first could increase the risk to a child. That decision depends on the circumstances, and it is always about the child's safety.

Myths and Facts

Myth	Fact
"It's just teenage drama"	Controlling behaviour can seriously affect a young person's wellbeing, and patterns

	learned young can continue into adulthood.
"It's not abuse if there's no violence"	Coercive control can be abuse without any violence.
"Jealousy shows they care"	Care means wanting someone to be happy and free. Control is a warning sign.
"Only girls are controlled"	Boys experience it too, and it happens in same-sex relationships and friendships.
"I should make them break up"	Forcing an immediate break-up can increase risk and push your child away. Plan with the school.



Who Can Help

At School

- **The Designated Safeguarding Lead (DSL)** and deputy DSLs: the staff whose job is to keep children safe. Their names are usually on the school website, in the safeguarding policy and on posters around school.
- The school nurse or health centre, and the school counsellor

Outside School

- **National Domestic Abuse Helpline (Refuge)**: 0808 2000 247, free, 24 hours
- **NSPCC Helpline**: 0808 800 5000 (Monday to Friday 10am to 4pm), or help@nspcc.org.uk
- **YoungMinds Parents Helpline**: 0808 802 5544 (Monday, Thursday and Friday 9:30am to 4pm; Tuesday and Wednesday 9:30am to 6pm)
- **Respect Phonenumber**: 0808 802 4040 (Monday to Friday 10am to 5pm), for anyone worried about their own behaviour in a relationship
- **Galop National LGBT+ Domestic Abuse Helpline (18 and over)**: 0800 999 5428 (Monday and Tuesday 9:15am to 8pm, Wednesday to Friday 9:15am to 4:30pm)
- **Galop Children and Young People's Service (LGBT+ young people aged 13 to 25)**: if you are under 18, use the online referral form at galop.org.uk/make-a-referral, or call Childline on 0800 1111 (for your child)

- **Karma Nirvana (honour-based abuse and forced marriage):** 0800 5999 247 (Monday to Friday 9am to 5pm)
- **Childline** (for your child): 0800 1111, free, confidential, any time, or [childline.org.uk](https://www.childline.org.uk)
- **Emergency:** call 999

Contacts checked September 2026.

RESPOND Safeguarding Framework Parent Guides

Controlling Relationships: A Guide for Parents: Parent Guide 46 - Ages 8 to 18

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